



O2 Xda Atom

Small But Loaded

The hot new Xda Atom from O2 is a PDA phone that packs in loads of features in an extremely small form factor. The Atom lives true to its name, and packs a punch in a diminutive casing. Measuring 58 x 102 x 18.5 mm and weighing just 140 gm, the Atom is a tad smaller than its predecessor, the highly successful Xda II Mini.

Encased in an elegant piano-black casing, the Atom sports a 2.7-inch screen. The front facia also includes large Send and End keys, a circular five-way navigation key, two keys assigned to the Start Menu and the MediaPlus application respectively, and two tiny speakers. You can find two volume keys on the left, a voice recorder and camera keys on the right, and a power button on top next to the stylus silo. The camera lens, self-portrait mirror and flash are located on the rear, while the bottom is where you will find the USB connector, headphone socket and reset button.

Powered by an Intel PXA272 processor running at 416 MHz, the Atom comes with 128 MB of ROM and 64 MB of RAM. You can add more memory by using the mini-SD slot located on top. The 2.7-inch touch-screen supports 262K colours at a resolution of 240 x 320. Connectivity options include tri-band GPRS/EDGE functionality, infrared, Bluetooth and Wi-Fi 802.11b—basically everything a globe-

trotting user would need. The camera is a 2-megapixel CMOS that can capture both stills and video. Other goodies include an integrated FM tuner, integrated strobe Flash, and a stereo wired headset. You



can even record from FM in the WAV or AMR formats. The device synchronises with a PC using the bundled USB cable.

The Atom runs the new Windows Mobile 5.0 operating system, the most notable feature of which, in our opinion, is persistent storage. This means that unlike with devices based on the earlier Windows Mobile 2003, this baby will not lose any data or installed programs when you run out of battery.

The Pocket Word, Excel and PowerPoint

have been rechristened Word Mobile, Excel Mobile and PowerPoint Mobile, with added support for embedded images, charts and tables. Standard PIM applications such as Calendar, Tasks and Notes are all there. O2 has thrown in quite a few of their own applications—noteworthy of which include O2 MediaPlus, SMS Plus and Equalizer.

MediaPlus provides an interface akin to that of Windows Media Center, and gives you the ability to play and view various media—radio, music, pictures and video, from a single window. O2 SMS Plus lets you view your text messages in an instant messaging format. Apart from these, you also get useful utilities such as an Auto Configurator, a photo editing application and a self-diagnostic tool.

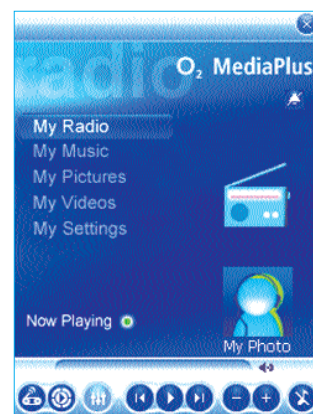
Coming to performance and usability: the glossy casing attracts fingerprints and dust, so be prepared to spend a fair bit of time cleaning your phone! The 416 MHz processor is capable of running most applications and games with ease, and will even let you multitask. The new OS still retains the nagging “Smart Minimise” feature, which does not close applications even when you tap the Close button. However, this can be easily circumvented by using a task manager such as SPB Pocket Plus or SmallMenu (or using the Memory module in Settings to shut down applications manually). Phone clarity is very decent, even in areas with low network coverage.

You can use the speakerphone in a noisy environment. The stylus is a bit skinny, but the touch-screen is quite sensitive. You can use the virtual keyboard or handwriting recognition to input text. The screen display itself is quite vibrant, but visibility is reduced significantly under sunlight.

The camera application is quite slow, and does not redeem itself in the quality department—images taken in low light turn out to be quite noisy.

Audio output from the inbuilt speakers is decent, but the wired stereo headset provides much better quality when listening to music. The 1530mAh user-replaceable lithium-polymer battery lasts for a decent two to three days with standard usage.

Features-wise, the Atom has just about every feature one would want. Sure, you can buy a laptop at this price, but can you carry it in your pocket?



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Rating

